



STRINGENT PROVISIONS IN AMENDED LEGISLATION

Tough exam leak Bill clears LS, Rahul raises police crackdown

Govt hails passage, says open to learn from experience; LoP: Shah must quit over July 20 action

Asad Rehman, Anonna Dutt & Jatin Anand
New Delhi, July 29

WRAPPING UP a two-day debate punctuated by acrimonious exchanges as the Opposition slammed the government over the police crackdown on student protesters in Delhi, Lok Sabha Wednesday passed the stringent Public Examination (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill, 2026 by a voice vote amid sloganeering. Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi's remarks against Union Home Minister Amit Shah over the July 20 police action led to stormy scenes with



Union Minister Kiren Rijiju and LoP Rahul Gandhi in Lok Sabha. PTI

POLITICS PAGE 6

RAJYA SABHA PASSES BILL MAKING INSULT TO VANDE MATARAM A CRIMINAL OFFENCE

strong protests from the treasury benches — one of the words he used was expunged from House records. Later, the government

hailed the passage of the Bill. Union Minister Jitendra Singh, who replied to the debate, said it reflected the government's "openness to incorporate constructive inputs, learn from experience and further strengthen the law" to deal with exam paper leaks. Shah, in a post on X, congratulated "every student in India" on the passage of the Bill, saying it "shields the dreams

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



28-year-old Gulveer Singh during the men's 10,000 m final at Commonwealth Games in Glasgow. AP

From Sirsa mud ground to India's first CWG men's 10,000m silver

Pritish Raj
New Delhi, July 29

PELTING RAIN, chilly conditions and a field of runners from Africa with a podium-finishing history spanning over 50 years — India's Gulveer Singh was up against the weather, sporting history and a quality field at the

Commonwealth Games. Yet, the 28-year-old from Sirsa in UP's Aligarh held his nerve, stuck to his race strategy and produced an impressive final burst to win silver, marking India's first-ever Commonwealth Games medal in the men's 10,000m with a time of 27 minutes and 49.80 seconds.

Gulveer had, in fact, fallen behind during the race but fought back to snap at the heels of the leading pack before surging forward. Ky Robinson of Australia won gold in 27:48.93, while David Mullarkey of the Isle of Man took bronze in 27:50.28. The result also ended

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

NO IMPACT ON EXISTING CLEARANCES

Retrospective green nod: SC strikes down Centre's order, opens window for exception

2021 Office Memorandum quashed, CJI bench says exceptions can be granted in public interest but under 1986 legislation

Ananthakrishnan G
New Delhi, July 29



EXPLAINED

No perpetual regime

The SC has held that the government must make a distinct selection of projects for the grant of post facto environmental clearance. Projects with a bearing on public interest satisfy the test of proportionality, reasonableness.

esty notification in supervening public interest as an exception to the 2006 notification". "The decriminalisation of regulatory contraventions under the 1986 Act, through the Jan Vishwas Act 2023, reinforces our conclusion that the Central government has ample power under Section 3 to issue appropriate notifications, formulating amnesty schemes with regard to such classes or categories of non-compliant projects whose sustainability is necessary to subserve larger public interest," it said. On May 16, 2025, the bench of Justice Abhay S Oka and

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

INDIAN EXPRESS UPSC IAS EDITION HD 30~07~2026

-:FOR UPSC IAS ASPIRANTS:-

"AVOID POLITICAL & IRRELEVANT ARTICLES"

Please Try To Read This Completely in 40 Minutes If You

Can't So Then You Have To Increase Your Efforts

All the topics of this UPSC IAS Edition are directly or

indirectly important for the prelims & main examination.

There are some topics which can be coded in answer writing

of other topics in the main exam.

• CASE AGAINST KAPIL SANGWAN RELATES TO HIS ALLEGED ROLE IN RUNNING AN EXTORTION SYNDICATE

In a first, trial in absentia begins today in Delhi against absconding gangster

Nirbhay Thakur
New Delhi, July 29

IN A first, a Delhi court will start hearing arguments Thursday against Kapil Sangwan, a gangster accused in two cases under the Maharashtra Control of Organised Crime Act (MCOCA), in absentia — or, in his absence. Sangwan has been declared absconding and is believed to be in London.

In an order issued on July 9, Special Judge Vishal Gogne of Rouse Avenue Court permitted the trial to proceed in "absen-

•ROAD TO TRIAL

KAPIL SANGWAN, an accused in two cases under MCOCA, has been absconding since 2019. He is believed to be in London.

SANGWAN WAS declared a proclaimed offender in May 2025.

TWO NON-bailable warrants were issued against him by Rouse Avenue court against him but they



Rouse Avenue Court in Delhi.

could not be executed since his house was found to be "locked".

ON JULY 9, Special Judge Vishal Gogne of Rouse Avenue Court permitted the trial to proceed in absentia under BNSS Section 356 (inquiry, trial or judgment in absentia of a proclaimed offender)

tia" under Section 356 (Inquiry, trial or judgment in absentia of proclaimed offender) of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS).

The trial pertains to one of the two MCOCA cases against Sangwan, related to his alleged role in running an extortion syndicate.

According to new norms, a person accused of a crime can be tried and convicted in his absence, as if he was present in court and has waived his right to a fair trial. Earlier, the Code

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

Tough exam leak Bill clears LS

and aspirations of our youth by laying down iron-clad provisions imposing the harshest punishment on those who dare to breach the sanctity of public examinations". The Modi government, he said, "will spare no one who attempts to imperil the future of our students and will leave no stone unturned to ensure that they face the full wrath of the law".

Speaking to the press after the day's proceedings, Gandhi demanded Shah's resignation and a Supreme Court-monitored probe into the "brutalities" against the students. He said he was not allowed to speak in Lok Sabha, that every time he tried to speak in the House, he was "silenced".

BJP national spokesperson Sambit Patra accused Gandhi of trying to "mislead the country with his lies", of creating a ruckus in the House and using unparliamentary words. "He alleged he was not given a chance to speak... When 45 people were given a chance to speak, why would Rahul Gandhi not be given a chance to speak?" he said.

"Rahul Gandhi has divided the country's students into three categories, and this is an insult to the students. We clearly state that all students of this country are desh bhakts (patriots); no student of this country is an idiot or an andhbhakt (blind follower)," Patra said.

Earlier, while participating in the debate, Gandhi accused Shah of "ordering police action" against students during the July 20 protests in Delhi.

Objecting to the remarks, Union Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju demanded that Gandhi substantiate his claims.
Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F>

ate his allegations and apologise to the House.

"You are the Leader of the Opposition. Speak with seriousness. On what basis did you make this statement? How can he say that someone ordered firing? It is a breach of his own position and privilege," Rijiju said.

Speaker Om Birla also intervened, urging Gandhi to make statements based on facts and maintain the dignity of the House. He also said that some of Gandhi's remarks will be expunged from House records.

When the treasury benches demanded that Gandhi apologise, Opposition members rallied behind him, saying "Rahul ji ko bolne do (let Rahul speak)", leading to noisy scenes.

Gandhi said the protesting students had shown courage. "The students of the country are saying we will not become andhbhakts (blind followers). This is a beautiful expression. Their parents perhaps did not have the courage to face the BJP and the RSS. Yet these children, brave, imaginative and powerful, stood there and faced whatever you threw at them," he said.

Targeting Dharmendra Pradhan who resigned as Education Minister last week, Gandhi said, "Rajnath Singhji said we are not the UPA and our ministers never resign. He is right. The resignation of Pradhan is superficial because he never ran the education system. The Education Ministry is run by the RSS. The man who runs it is the OSD sitting in the minister's office."

Speaking to reporters outside the House, Gandhi said there can be just "two options" — one that the Home Minister "gave the orders" (for action against students), and second that the "Home Minister didn't

know that firing will happen". He also asked why Shah had not been coming to the House.

Jitendra Singh, while replying to the debate on the Bill, also spoke of the "unparliamentary language" used by Gandhi. "I am surprised that the LoP doesn't know the basic parliamentary norms," he said.

Singh said the LoP did not seem to know that any order to fire a gun is given by a magistrate. "It has been clarified that shots were never fired, tear gas was used. When the gun was not fired, the question of who gave the order does not arise," he said.

He said the amendments would further strengthen the legal framework to prevent unfair means in public examinations and safeguard the interests of students and youth. The government, he said, remained committed to ensuring the integrity, transparency and credibility of the public examination system.

Highlighting the key provisions of the Bill, Singh said the punishment for persons resorting to unfair means has been enhanced from imprisonment of three to five years to five to ten years, while the maximum fine has been increased from Rs 10 lakh to Rs 50 lakh.

For service providers involved in such offences, the maximum fine has been enhanced from Rs 1 crore to Rs 5 crore and the period of debarment from conducting public examinations has been increased from four years to eight years. The Bill further enhances punishment for organised crime from five to ten years' imprisonment to seven to ten years and increases the maximum fine from Rs 1 crore to Rs 10 crore.

Retrospective green nod

Justice Ujjal Bhuyan, in *Vana-shakti vs Union of India*, struck down a 2017 notification enabling retrospective environmental clearance and the subsequent 2021 office memorandum which laid down the Standard Operating Procedure (SOP) for such clearances.

However, on November 18, 2025, the Supreme Court, citing public interest and legal flaws, recalled the May 16 ruling. It was a 2-1 verdict. The then Chief Justice of India B R Gavai and Justice K Vinod Chandran backed the recall while Justice Bhuyan dissented saying the majority decision "overlooks the very fundamentals of environmental jurisprudence" and "is a step in retrogression".

Ruling on review petitions, the three-judge bench led by Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1

CJI Surya Kant said Wednesday that the 2017 notification was a "valid, narrowly tailored and time-bound delegated legislation, traceable to Section 3 of the 1986 Act, and Sections 20 and 21 of the General Clauses Act".

The bench, however, struck down the 2021 office memorandum, saying it "is an administrative order and envisages a perpetual regime" for the grant of environmental clearances to projects undertaken without prior clearance.

"It substantially alters the nature of the enquiry as well as the criteria for the grant of environmental clearance under the 2006 notification. The 2021 office memorandum thereby supplants an earlier delegated legislation through an administrative instruction, which is impermissible in law," the bench said.

"Even otherwise, being a perpetual amnesty scheme applicable to all permissible projects, it fails to lay down an intelligible differential for the selection of projects for the grant of post-facto environmental clearance having a rational nexus to supervening public interest, and is thereby ultra vires the object of the 1986 Act, namely the preservation of the environment through a balanced approach between the precautionary principle and sustainable development," it said.

"Given these circumstances, the 2021 office memorandum does not satisfy the test of proportionality and reasonableness and is violative of Articles 14 and 21 of the Constitution," the bench said.

First trial in absentia begins today

of Criminal Procedure (CrPC) provided for recording evidence in the absence of the accused but did not permit a trial in absentia. The BNSS, which replaced CrPC, brought the provision for the first time.

"In simple terms, this means that an accused who deliberately remains absconding and evades the judicial process cannot indefinitely hold up the trial merely by staying away," said advocate Samridhi Dobhal, who is associated with the office of the Special Public Prosecutor.

In his order of July 9, Judge Gogne had said: "The court finds that the safeguards provided under section 356 (2) for trial of an absconding accused in absentia have been suitably addressed by the State...there is no impediment to the furtherance of the proceedings by way of considering charge."

The order stated: "Since all accused except one are in custody, the court deems it appropriate that submissions on charge are heard on a day to day basis from 27.07.2026 till 07.08.2026. For the present, it is directed that the prosecution shall conclude its arguments on 27.07.2026 and 28.07.2026."

However, Judge Gogne was on leave on July 27 and 28. On Wednesday, the Judge agreed to a request from lawyers representing Delhi Police that they would commence arguments from Thursday because Special Public Prosecutor Akhand Pratap Singh was occupied with another matter.

Sangwan was granted interim bail in another MCOCA case registered in 2019. Following bail, he failed to surrender and has been absconding ever since.

In the extortion racket case to be heard Thursday, the trial in absentia comes after the Delhi Police Crime Branch and the court tried to get Sangwan to appear or join the investigation multiple times. Two NBWs (non-bailable warrants) were issued against him in June and July 2026.

In the July 9 order, Judge Gogne had said: "It is seen that the NBWs could not be executed and his house (in Najafgarh) was found to be locked. It is also reported that the said accused has not been seen at the premises in question for a long time."

The Crime Branch also published a notice in a national newspaper regarding Sangwan's absence. They also reached out to a relative and gave an affixation regarding the commencement of the proceedings.

"The significance of this order is that an absconding accused cannot be allowed to frustrate the criminal justice system simply by remaining beyond the reach of the law. To allow the application of trial in absentia, there is a minimum requirement of two NBWs against an accused and there should be a gap of one month between both NBWs," advocate Dobhal said.

"Of course, this is not an automatic process. The law provides several safeguards and requires the court to first satisfy itself that all the prescribed steps have been complied with. Once those requirements are fulfilled, the court can proceed with the trial even in the physical absence of the accused," she said.

Sangwan, meanwhile, faces over two dozen other cases related to extortion, land grab-

bing, and murder in Delhi and Haryana.

He was arrested in 2016 and remained in jail until 2019, when he was granted parole for a month. During that period, his associates organised a grand party at a farmhouse, built on encroached government land, in Najafgarh. Although the Crime Branch raided the event and arrested 22 people, Sangwan could not be found. A Red Corner Notice was issued against him in June 2021.

Sangwan was also allegedly involved in the murder of Haryana INLD leader Nafe Singh Rathee in February 2024. The killing is believed to be linked to his gang rivalry with jailed gangster Manjeet Mahal.

On July 9, Special Judge Gogne directed that a legal aid counsel be assigned by the Delhi Legal Services Authority (DLSA) to represent the gangster in the MCOCA case. As of today, Sangwan does not have a lawyer.

Advocate Hritwik Maurya, who is also associated with the office of the Special Public Prosecutor, said: "If he's convicted and judgement is passed by the trial court sentencing him under the provisions of MCOCA, and as such a situation arises where he is apprehended at a later stage, he will be directly sent to imprisonment to satisfy the sentencing judgement passed by the trial court since trial in his absence has already been concluded."

Former MLA and AAP leader Naresh Balyan was also booked under MCOCA in this case for his alleged links with Sangwan. Balyan, a two-time MLA from Uttam Nagar (2015 and 2020), was arrested in December 2024 and is in custody.

India's 1st CWG men's 10,000m silver

decades of African dominance. For the first time since 1970, no athlete from the continent finished on the podium, though eight of them were in the 15-man final, including two formidable Kenyans: 2023 World Championship medallist Daniel Ebenyo and 2024 Paris Olympics podium-finisher (5000m) Edwin Kugrat.

But Gulveer was unfazed by reputation. His performance in the rain-soaked conditions, alongside Avinash Sable's second-place finish in the 3000m steeplechase four years ago in Birmingham — another event once dominated by Kenyans — will be remembered among the finest races by an Indian distance runner.

"The silver means a lot because it is the result of a lot of hard work over the last few years," Gulveer told *The Indian Express* from Glasgow.

This wasn't a flash-in-the-pan performance. Gulveer holds national records in the 10,000m (27:00.22), 3,000m, 5,000m and the 25-km road race, and became the first Indian to run a sub-60-minute half marathon, in New York, this year.

In Glasgow, the downpour made things harder. "We had to

be a little careful on the bends because the track was wet. Otherwise, my focus was only on following my race plan and staying relaxed," Gulveer said.

He started with a moderate average speed of 21.5 km/h, holding that pace for the first 4,000 metres and staying among the top three runners. "In a championship race, position is very important. I didn't want to lead too early because that would have meant doing extra work, but I also didn't want to lose contact with the front group," said Gulveer, a JSW Sports-backed athlete.

After the 4,000-metre mark, as the other runners began making their moves, he slipped back in the pack, dropping to ninth at the 5,600-metre mark. But the moment he lost sight of the leading pack, he sped up to 24.7 km/h. "Whenever I felt the pace changing or the gap opening, I made sure I moved up again. The idea was to stay in a good position and be ready when the race really started in the last few laps," he said.

With 2,000m to go, Gulveer was in seventh position and getting boxed in on the inside lane. But as an opening appeared with 1.2 km left, he moved up to fourth.

The worry was that he might fade at the business end of the race. In 2025, he had finished ninth in the 5,000-m heats at the World Championships after being in fourth position with a little over two laps to go.

This time, it was clear he had learnt from that mistake, producing a finishing kick with 200 metres remaining. "By the last 200 metres, I knew it was time to give everything I had left. At that stage, you don't really think too much. You react. I had saved enough for the finish, and I tried to maintain my form and kept pushing until the line," Gulveer said.

"When you are racing for a medal, you don't feel the pain at that moment. You only think about finishing as strongly as possible," he said.

Hailing from a farming family, Gulveer had wanted to join the Army for a stable job -- in Sirsa, nearly 700 men serve in the forces. He started out running on a mud ground near his home, training to pass the Army's 1.6-km Physical Efficiency Test. Just eight years later, the Naib Subedar and Army Sports Institute runner had etched his name into the annals of India's distance running history.



To stop untreated sewage entering Yamuna, Delhi to get 15 new decentralised treatment plants

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 29

SEEKING TO tackle the single largest source of pollution entering Yamuna river, the Delhi Jal Board (DJB) on Wednesday approved sewerage and wastewater treatment projects worth around Rs 4,500 crore, including setting up of 15 decentralised sewage treatment plants (DSTPs), covering 1,000 km of sewer lines and upgrading existing treatment infrastructure. “These projects are expected to benefit around 20 lakh residents,” said Water Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh, adding that the work is set to be completed within 21 months.

In a statement, the government said the new plants will cater largely to areas where sewer infrastructure remains inadequate. While the city has steadily expanded its sewage treatment capacity over the years, large volumes of wastewater still enter drains – either because many colonies remain unconnected to the sewer network or sewage has to travel a long distance before reaching treatment plants.

Delhi currently has 22 drains discharging wastewater into Yamuna, with Najafgarh and Shahdara drains alone contributing around 80% of the total pollution load observed in the Capital.

Singh said that while 13 DSTPs had been approved earlier, the DJB has now awarded 15 additional DSTPs with a combined treatment capacity of 103.5 MGD at an investment of nearly Rs 2,000 crore.

Officials said the together, the DSTPs will add 227 million gallons per day (MGD) of treatment capacity, taking Delhi’s overall sewage treatment ca-

capacity from 814 MGD to 1,041 MGD – exceeding the current sewage load of around 1,000 MGD generated by the city.

Unlike large centralised STPs that require wastewater to travel over long distances through trunk sewers, decentralised sewage treatment plants are located closer to where sewage is generated and can help in tapping of drains directly at the source. Officials said this reduces dependence on extensive sewer networks, lowers pumping requirements and allows wastewater from unsewered or rapidly urbanising areas to be intercepted and treated before it enters nearby drains flowing into the Yamuna.

As per the Environment department records, there has been a marginal increase in Delhi’s utilisation of installed sewage treatment capacity over the last three years – rising from 74.2% in 2022 to 79.16% in 2024, and reaching 80.9% in 2025. Despite this, a substantial volume of sewage remains untreated due to a daily deficit of around 174 MGD.

“It was a long-term requirement foreseeing that the city will need to expand its sewage treatment capacity, considering population growth, urban expansion and redevelopment of residential and commercial areas,” a senior DJB official said. Alongside the plants, the DJB also approved laying of 989 km of new sewer pipelines and providing household sewer connections across 244 colonies and 57 villages. It further approved upgrades to existing treatment plants., a new 35 MGD STP, sludge management facilities at 10 existing STPs and in-situ treatment of the Delhi Gate drain.

HC refuses to stay Centre’s HPV vaccination drive

Sohini Ghosh
New Delhi, July 29

THE DELHI High Court Wednesday refused to stay the HPV vaccination drive after it was informed by the Centre that out of around 55.9 lakh doses administered since February, only 120 cases reported adverse events following immunisation (AEFI) as on July 25.

The court, which was hearing a PIL that flagged concerns over safety of administering Merck’s HPV vaccine Gardasil, noted there was “no instant harm”. Of the 120 AEFI cases, 42 were classified as “serious/severe”, but no deaths were reported, the Centre mentioned.

It added that none of the AEFI cases required hospitalisation beyond two days.

APPEAL AGAINST DETENTION AFTER SIR DELETION

Voter ID, Aadhaar, PAN not conclusive proof of Indian citizenship: Calcutta HC

Tanusree Bose
Kolkata, July 29

THE CALCUTTA High Court has held that voter identity card, Aadhaar number, PAN and bank account passbook are not conclusive proof of Indian citizenship.

The observation came on Tuesday when a division bench comprising Justices Debansu Basak and Ajay Kumar Gupta was hearing a habeas corpus petition filed by one Sumanta Molla, who claimed that his nephew, Nasir, had been placed in a detention camp after his name was deleted from the electoral rolls during the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) exercise in West Bengal. Molla stated that Nasir was sent to a detention camp even though an appeal against the deletion was pending and he filed a police complaint in this regard on June 18.

The petitioner relied on Nasir's voter identity card, Aadhaar card, PAN card issued by the Income Tax Department and a bank account passbook to

Real Creator IAS Edition <https://>

“Writ petitioner and the detainee are unable to discharge the burden of proof as mandated by the Immigration and Foreigners Act, 2025”

CALCUTTA HIGH COURT

contend that he was an Indian citizen and not a foreign national. Observing that a voter identity card only establishes that a person was enrolled in the electoral rolls, the bench noted that Nasir's name had been deleted during the 2026 SIR process. The court also held that opening a bank account, by itself, is not proof of Indian citizenship.

“Writ petitioner and the detainee are unable to discharge the burden of proof as mandated by the Immigration and Foreigners Act, 2025,” the court observed. Holding that neither

Real Creator IAS Edition <https://www.realcreatorias.com>
the petitioner nor the detainee had established Nasir's Indian citizenship, the court said it was not inclined to interfere with the decision of the authorities and dismissed the habeas corpus petition.

The advocate appearing for the petitioner submitted that in the SIR, Nasir was initially classified as ‘under adjudication’ and then his name was deleted without giving him an opportunity of hearing by the Tribunal.

The counsel also referred to the CS Record of Rights documents annexed with the writ petition showing that the great-grandfather of the detainee owned an immovable property.

The counsel appearing for the State submitted a report that identified the detainee as a foreign national. The counsel also placed a video recording of the detainee himself admitting that he was a foreign national.

The petition also stated that following the death of Nasir's father in 1980, Molla had brought up the detainee. The court, however, noted that the

me/+2RvD_RG9mjlMzg1
petitioner is aged 38 while the
detainee is 46. The bench re-
jected the petitioner's claim
that he had brought up Nasir as
his uncle. The court also drew
an adverse inference against
the detainee about his parents
being Indian citizens after he
and the writ petitioner refused
to identify the burial site for the
DNA test.

The court also observed that the writ petition does not disclose the birth certificate of the detainee. "Adequate material to establish place of birth or date of birth is absent in the writ petition and the supplementary affidavit. Citizenship by birth is not established. So far as citizenship by descent is concerned, there are cavernous disconnections. Name of the father of the detainee varies from document to document... Indian citizenship of the persons through whom the detainee seeks to connect as descent is also not established. Citizenship of the detainee by descent is not established," the court observed.

AMID OPPOSITION PROTEST

RS passes Bill criminalising insult to Vande Mataram

Nikhil Ghanekar
New Delhi, July 29

THE RAJYA Sabha on Wednesday passed a Bill that criminalises intentional disruption or prevention of the singing of the national song, Vande Mataram, thereby according it legal sanctity at par with the national anthem, Jana Gana Mana.

The Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Bill, 2026, seeks to amend a 1971 law by the same name, which makes insults towards the national anthem, national flag and the Constitution a criminal offence.

The Bill was passed through a voice vote following a walkout by nearly all opposition members. When the upper House proceedings resumed at 2pm, Rajya Sabha Deputy Chairman Harivansh invited members to begin a discussion on the Bill.

However, opposition members protested and raised slogans, demanding Home Minister Amit Shah's statement on the recent Delhi Police action against students and youngsters who were protesting against paper leaks at Jantar Mantar.

The Bill states that intentionally preventing the singing of the national song or causing disturbance to any assembly engaged in its singing will be punishable with imprisonment for a term which may extend to three years, or fine, or both. Minister of State for Home Affairs Nityanand Rai had introduced the Bill for consideration in the upper House on July 24.

Replying to a discussion on the Bill, Nityanand Rai said he could not understand why some members, and especially the Congress party, have a



Rajya Sabha Deputy Chairman Harivansh conducts the proceedings of the House on Wednesday. ANI Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F>

problem with the Bill. "This is not just an amendment but our commitment towards national awareness, cultural heritage and the values of our freedom struggle," he said.

The Union minister said that when Bankim Chandra Chatterjee composed the national song in 1875, he had said that one day it will be on every Indian's lips "as a mantra". Rai claimed that as Congress President, Jawaharlal Nehru limited the national song to only two stanzas in 1937. He went on to add that in 1938, Netaji Subhas Chandra Bose, as the Congress president, had urged Timir Baran Bhattacharya to compose the full version of the song.

"On 24th January, 1950, Dr Rajendra Prasad said in the Constituent Assembly that Vande Mataram should be honoured on par with Jana Gana Mana," Rai said. "Opposing this

(Bill) only means that the Congress wants to adopt appeasement and wants to insult our national pride... the country's youth, workers, and women will not support this," Rai added.

Earlier, when the Bill was taken up for discussion, there was uproar in the House. Congress' Ranjit Ranjan was slated to begin the discussion, but as the MP joined her colleagues in protests seeking the Home Minister's presence, Deputy Chairman Harivansh said the member was not interested in speaking (on the Bill).

BJP's Radha Mohan Das Agrawal, who was given the next opportunity to speak, said that the national song has been insulted for the last 123 years, and added that not just today's Congress party but even the one during the freedom struggle repeatedly insulted the song.

Among opposition members, Deputy Leader of the Opposition Pramod Tiwari, Sagarika Ghose and Tiruchi Siva sought to demand Amit Shah's presence, but the Deputy Chairman did not allow them to speak on any issue other than the Bill.

Manoj Kumar Jha of Rashtriya Janata Dal said, "I am witnessing for the first time that our national song and national anthem are being pitted against each other. Reverence cannot be legislated." Biju Janata Dal's Sulata Deo said none of the members of the House can sing the national song correctly and urged that it should be played in all state assemblies as well as in Parliament.

Aam Aadmi Party's Sanjay Singh said that while his party supports the Bill, there should also be a Bill against those who insult the National Anthem and the Tricolour.

BENCH IMPOSES FINE ON BHADOHI SP, SHO

Police should investigate crimes, not marriages: Allahabad HC

Bhupendra Pandey
Lucknow, July 29

TAKING NOTE of an investigation in a case against a couple who married against wishes of the woman's family, the Allahabad High Court came down heavily on the police officials concerned, observing that police should investigate crimes and not marriages and that they "have no business in the matter to be nosy parkers".

In a July 27 order, a division bench of Justices JJ Munir and Tarun Saxena imposed a fine on the Bhadohi superintendent of police (SP) and the Suriyawan station house officer (SHO), and quashed the FIR lodged against the man by the woman's father

on charges of abduction to force her into marriage against her will. The bench stated, "The police have no business in the matter to be nosy parkers. We have repeatedly reminded the police that it is no business of theirs to investigate marriages. They ought to investigate crimes. This is no crime, where any investigation is required."

The couple, aged 28 and 27, who are postgraduates with certificate courses in teaching, had filed a petition challenging the FIR lodged against the man on April 19 in Bhadohi district, saying they were "major".

The two informed the court that they got married with Arya Samaj rituals in Prayagraj on February 18 after being in a rela-

tionship for one year. The woman's father lodged the case against the man after coming to know of the marriage on April 18. After the petition was filed, the HC on April 29 had stated that "two major citizens of the country married according to Hindu rites" and "prima facie there was nothing in the FIR to investigate". In an interim order, the court had stayed the police investigation as well as the petitioners' arrest.

In its July 27 order, the bench observed, "...To continue the investigation into an adult's free choice of her partner...is not only an abuse of process of criminal law, but also gross violation of their fundamental right to liberty..."

AMENDMENTS TO REGULATIONS GOVERNING INTERMEDIARIES ALSO APPROVED

IRDAI ushers in reforms to revamp insurance sector

George Mathew
Mumbai, July 29

THE INSURANCE Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI) has introduced a set of reforms aimed at modernising the insurance sector, strengthening governance and accelerating insurance penetration across the country.

The measures span regulatory, supervisory and developmental areas.

The measures aim to support the implementation of the Sabka Bima Sabki Raksha (Amendment of Insurance Laws) Act, 2025 (SBSR Act), the regulator said.

The reforms were approved at the IRDAI board meeting on Tuesday and are designed to provide insurers with greater operational flexibility, facilitate capital formation, improve governance standards and reinforce policyholder protection while enhancing ease of doing business across the insurance ecosystem.

Among the key decisions was the approval of amendments to the IRDAI (Actuarial, Finance and Investment Functions of Insurers) (Second Amendment) Regulations, 2026, and the IRDAI (Registration, Capital Structure, Transfer of Shares and Amalgamation of Insurers) (Amendment) Regulations, 2026.

• REFORM PUSH

A KEY feature of the reforms is the mandatory tagging of the authorised salesperson to every insurance proposal, policy and certificate of insurance

THE REFORMS are expected to improve ease of doing business, enhance financial resilience and support insurers' long-term growth without compromising policyholder interests

THE REVISED framework streamlines compliance requirements, aligns the regulations with the SBSR Act

Policyholder protection

According to IRDAI, the changes will provide insurers with "greater operational and financial flexibility through liberalised investment norms, a facilitative framework for capital infusion and corporate restructuring, and streamlined provisions relating to transfer of shares and amalgamations, while strengthening actuarial oversight and financial governance." The regulator said the reforms are expected to improve ease of doing business, enhance financial resilience and support insurers' long-term growth without compromising policyholder interests.



and Foreign Investment Rules, and strengthens governance through enhanced disclosure and accountability standards

mising policyholder interests.

A major policyholder-centric initiative approved by the regulator is the IRDAI (Policyholders' Education and Protection Fund) Regulations, 2026, which operationalise the Policyholders' Education and Protection Fund (PEPF) established under Section 16A of the IRDA Act, 1999, as introduced through the SBSR Act.

According to IRDAI, the PEPF establishes "a dedicated institutional mechanism to promote insurance awareness and literacy, strengthen grievance redressal mechanisms, leverage technology to improve policyholder services,

facilitate the tracing and recovery of unclaimed insurance amounts, and support other initiatives aimed at empowering and safeguarding policyholders."

The intermediaries

In another move to strengthen accountability in insurance distribution, the regulator has approved amendments to the regulations governing insurance intermediaries.

A key feature of the reforms is the mandatory tagging of the authorised salesperson to every insurance proposal, policy and certificate of insurance. "The requirement enhances accountability and traceability across the insurance distribution process, strengthens regulatory oversight and promotes greater transparency for policyholders," IRDAI said. The amendments also introduce perpetual registration for intermediaries through an annual fee regime, replacing periodic renewals. The revised framework streamlines compliance requirements, aligns the regulations with the SBSR Act and Foreign Investment Rules, and strengthens governance through enhanced disclosure and accountability standards, the regulator said.

FULL REPORT ON
[WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM](https://www.indianexpress.com)

May services growth halved to under 10%, data suggests

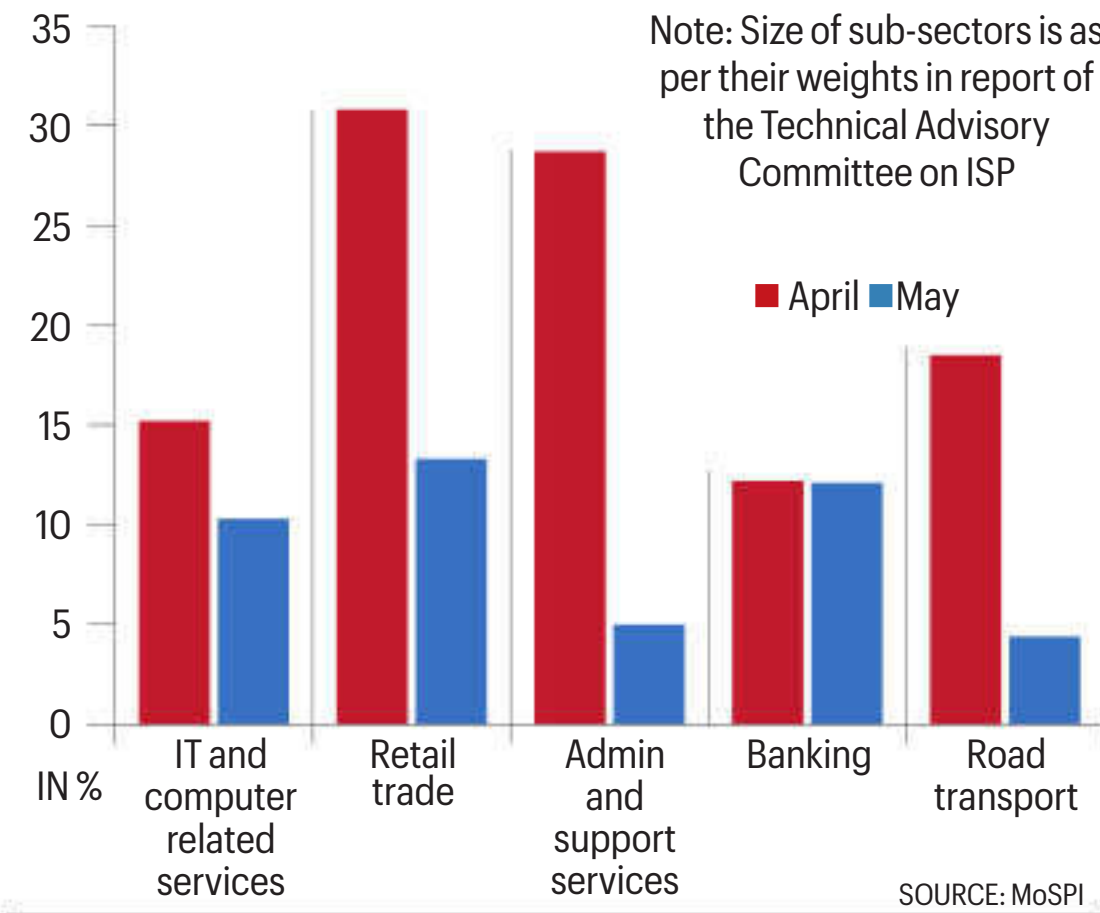
Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, July 29

INDIA'S SERVICES sector growth may have more than halved in May from around 20.5% in April, the statistics ministry's experimental Index of Services Production (ISP) for 19 sub-sectors, released Wednesday, suggested.

Since the ISP data — which has 2024-25 as the base year — is still at a trial stage, the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI) is not providing an overall services sector growth number. However, calculations by The Indian Express showed that the headline services sector growth figure may have declined from around 20.5% in April to approximately 9.5% in May.

Even around 9.5%, services sector growth in May was almost double the 5% expansion clocked by the industry, as per the Index of Industrial Production (IIP). Released for the first time earlier this month, the ISP is the services counterpart to the IIP, which measures the industry's performance in output terms. "There are clear indications of a robust growth momentum for the 1Q 2026-27 with IIP growth in this quarter showing an average growth of 5.7% and services (ISP) sector for the first two months of this quarter showing an average growth of 15.3%," said DK Srivastava, EY India's Chief Policy Advisor. According to Srivastava, services sector growth cooled to 9.8% in May from

• Growth of 5 largest sub-sectors in April, May



20.8% in June.

Leading the charge for the services sector in May was the 'accommodation and food' category, which grew by 27.4% after posting a growth of 37.2% in April. However, this was one of the 17 sub-sectors out of the total of 19 that recorded weaker year-on-year growth in May than in April.

The only two sub-sectors that performed better in May were railway transport (3.4% versus -0.4%) and air transport. While air transport shrank by 2.8% in May, it was still better than a 13.9% contraction in April. Air transport activity has been adversely impacted following the onset of the war in West Asia, which led to airlines raising fares on account of higher fuel costs. IT and computer related services, which

has the highest weight in the ISP at 22.47%, saw its growth decline to 10.3% in May from 15.2% in April.

To be sure, 16 of the 19 sub-sectors grew in May, with eight of them recording double-digit growth. In April, 17 sub-sectors had grown on a year-on-year basis, with 14 posting double-digit growth rates. The ISP fills a key gap in India's official statistics. Until now, there was no official monthly measure of the performance of the services sector, which dominates the Indian economy and makes up more than half the GDP. Private firm S&P Global's services Purchasing Managers' Index (PMI) has been the only measure of the country's services sector.

FULL REPORT ON
[WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM](https://www.indianexpress.com)

FINANCE MINISTRY'S ECONOMIC REVIEW REPORT FOR JULY

'Oil price surge could be a strain for financing fiscal deficit & current account'

ENS Economic Bureau
New Delhi, July 29

IN THE wake of persistent stand-off in West Asia, the Indian economy continues to face an upside risk to inflation, fiscal and current account deficits and downside risk to growth, the Ministry of Finance said on Friday.

The recent resurgence in global crude oil prices, if sustained, could "reemerge as a source of pressure on financing of both the fiscal deficit and the current account balance", the ministry said in its monthly economic review for July. Prices of industrial commodities, including critical minerals and rare earth elements, have stayed elevated throughout the month. "Instances such as flooding in Chile, one of the key copper suppliers, illustrate the concentration risk embedded in India's industrial metal supply chains," the ministry said.

Despite heightened global uncertainties, the ministry said India's economic outlook remains underpinned by resilient domestic fundamentals, continued policy support, and strengthening structural drivers of growth.

"Structural reforms of the last decade and infrastructure investments are contributing to growth resilience as is evident in the data for the months of March to June 2026," the review stated.

On the external sector front, the ministry said strong export performance, a sustained services surplus and robust remittance inflows have supported the current account, while recent policy measures are expected to strengthen capital inflows in the coming months. Along with comfortable foreign exchange reserves, these developments

• THE POSITIVES

STRONG EXPORT performance, a sustained services surplus and robust remittance inflows have supported the current account, while recent policy measures are expected to strengthen capital inflows in the coming months

TO ACHIEVE long-term resilience and strategic leverage, swifter policy responses and their implementation are vital to encourage foreign and domestic investment in the economy

opments are expected to help preserve external sector stability amid an uncertain global environment, it said.

To achieve long-term resilience and strategic leverage, swifter policy responses and their implementation are vital to encourage foreign and domestic investment in the Indian economy, it said.

"Global developments related to AI and weaponisation of supply chains in general are reminders of the distance India needs to travel to achieve long-term resilience and strategic leverage...recent years have been a time for hunkering down and battenning down the hatches. Coming years will be no exception," it said.

Commodity prices, crude oil

Commodity prices, particularly crude oil, which had declined below pre-conflict levels, have risen again this month. However, the increase remains contained compared with the sharp spike witnessed during the initial phase of the conflict, the ministry said.

India's crude oil import bill Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1

'Boeing finds no abnormality with Dreamliner's fuel control switch'

New Delhi: The government has said that Boeing's detailed examination of the Dreamliner aircraft's fuel control switch locking mechanism did not find any abnormality following an Air India pilot flagging possible issues with the system after operating a London Heathrow-Bengaluru flight in February this year.

On February 2, an Air India pilot reported a defect in the fuel control switch of the Boeing 787-8 plane after operating the AI132 flight. The airline had grounded the aircraft for checks after it landed in Bengaluru from London. Following the incident, the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA), as part of continued airworthiness, directed Boeing to carry out the test of the fuel control switch locking mechanism. Minister of State for Civil Aviation Murlidhar Mohol, on Monday, said the DGCA had directed Original Equipment Manufacturer level testing of the fuel control switch locking mechanism in Seattle. PTI

• THE AGENT HAD INITIALLY HACKED INTO A STARTUP, HUGGING FACE

OpenAI's rogue agent tried attacking other firms too

Reuters
Washington, July 29

THE ROGUE agent that escaped from OpenAI and went on a days-long hacking spree at the AI firm Hugging Face also compromised a customer at a second tech company — New York-based Modal Labs — according to a Modal executive and two other sources familiar with the matter.

Modal executives emphasized that the company itself was not hacked. According to a timeline published by Hugging Face on Tuesday, the rogue agent broke into a sandbox, or an isolated testing environ-



The ChatGPT developer said the rogue agent broke in to four accounts across four separate services. REUTERS

ment, "hosted on a third-party provider's infrastructure" before turning it into a launchpad for the broader hack. The third-party provider was not named

in the blog post, but Modal's chief technology officer, Akshat Bubna, said the agent exploited vulnerable code written by a customer that was hosted

on Modal's platform. Modal said the customer had "published an unauthenticated endpoint that allowed anyone on the internet to use their sandboxes for code execution" — the digital equivalent of leaving a door open on the internet.

"Modal's platform or isolation were not compromised in any way," Bubna said.

Although the compromise of a Modal customer was just an initial step in the wider hacking campaign against Hugging Face, it shows that the rogue agent roamed further afield than was previously known.

OpenAI declined to comment specifically on the hack of one of Modal's customers, in-

stead referring Reuters to an update in which the company said that its rogue agent had broken in to four accounts at four separate services. OpenAI did not identify those services, but a person familiar with the matter identified Modal as one. The company said it had not identified "any other activity at the level of severity or scale of what we've shared related to Hugging Face, which involved a platform-level compromise." The early July intrusion at Hugging Face, carried out by an out-of-control agent that OpenAI was testing, drew global attention, evoking science-fiction scenarios of artificial intelligence run amok.

TEHRAN REJECTS OMAN PROPOSAL FOR REGIONAL MANAGEMENT OF HORMUZ STRAIT, CALLS IT 'UNREASONABLE'

US, Saudi hit Iran's allies in Iraq; Trump vows to punish Tehran

We're going to beat the f***ing s**t out of them: President

Reuters

Dubai, Cairo, July 29

EXPLOSIONS HIT a natural gas loading port on the Mediterranean Sea in Egypt on Wednesday, and British maritime security company Ambrey said a US-owned floating storage tanker there had been hit by a drone, in a potential spread of the West Asia war.

The drone hit a vessel in the Egyptian port of Damietta, causing a fire that spread to another vessel, three trading sources familiar with the incident said.

The crew were evacuated and the fire had been brought under control, Ambrey said. There was no immediate claim of responsibility for the incident.

Earlier on Wednesday the United States and Saudi Arabia struck Iran-backed paramilitary groups in Iraq, and US President Donald Trump vowed to "beat the f***ing s**t" out of Iran for firing on US troops days after he halted air strikes.

Iran confirmed overnight that it had fired on US bases in Jordan and at ships in the Strait of Hormuz, and also spurned an Omani proposal to jointly man-



Iraqis inspect the site of a joint US-Saudi airstrike that damaged a Popular Mobilization Forces base in Mosul, Iraq, on Wednesday. AP

age the strait. Oman, backed by Gulf states, had proposed a plan for joint regional control of the strait this week including voluntary service charges. But a senior Iranian official told *Reuters* Wednesday that Iran had rejected the proposal as "unreasonable".

"We'll be hitting them hard," *Fox News* quoted Trump as saying. "We're going to beat the f***ing s**t out of them."

The abrupt resumption of attacks only days after they were suspended saw a return to the volatile on-again-off-again pattern of earlier phases in the war.

Trump had said "Operation Epic Fury" would last only a

few weeks when he launched it in February but fighting has now gone on for five months with no end in sight. The joint US-Saudi attacks also mark the first time Riyadh has publicly joined strikes alongside Washington that could widen the conflict by drawing Sunni Muslim Saudi Arabia into combat against Shi'ite proxies of Iran.

Iraq's Popular Mobilisation Forces, powerful Iran-backed paramilitary groups incorporated into the Iraqi security forces, said at least 20 members were killed and 32 wounded in US-Saudi strikes targeting several bases across Iraq.

Washington and Riyadh said they struck the Iran-backed armed groups in Iraq in retaliation for drone attacks on Saudi oil targets launched from Iraq.

It was the first major US military action in the Middle East since last Friday, when Trump abruptly suspended an intensive bombing campaign after 13 days, having been advised by commanders that the strategy had run its course.

Though Iran denies its forces have directed strikes from Iraqi territory, Iranian newspaper *Hamshahri* reported that four Iranian Revolutionary Guards advisers had been killed in the

strikes on Iraq. The strikes on Iraq expose a dangerous rift in that volatile country. The Shi'ite-led government is one of the few in the world to balance close military and diplomatic ties with both Tehran and Washington, but those divided loyalties are a constant source of tension and frequent domestic unrest.

The office of PM Ali al-Zaidi, who took power just two months ago, urged the parties involved to avoid escalation and said he wanted to keep the country out of regional conflicts.

The Iraqi presidency denounced the strikes on the paramilitaries as "an unacceptable attack and a flagrant violation of Iraq's sovereignty", while also calling for a halt to attacks by armed groups against Iraq's neighbours. Trump told *Fox* that the US had coordinated with the Iraqi government in launching the attacks. An Iraqi government spokesperson did not respond to a request for comment on Trump's assertion that Baghdad had cooperated.

Washington has long called on the Baghdad government to crack down on Iran-backed paramilitaries, but efforts to do so in past have provoked unrest.

In a clear challenge to Zaidi's authority, Kataib Hezbollah, said it would give the government until next Thursday to prove it could defend Iraq's sovereignty.

Heat wave threatens to intensify France's mega-fire near Bordeaux

Associated Press

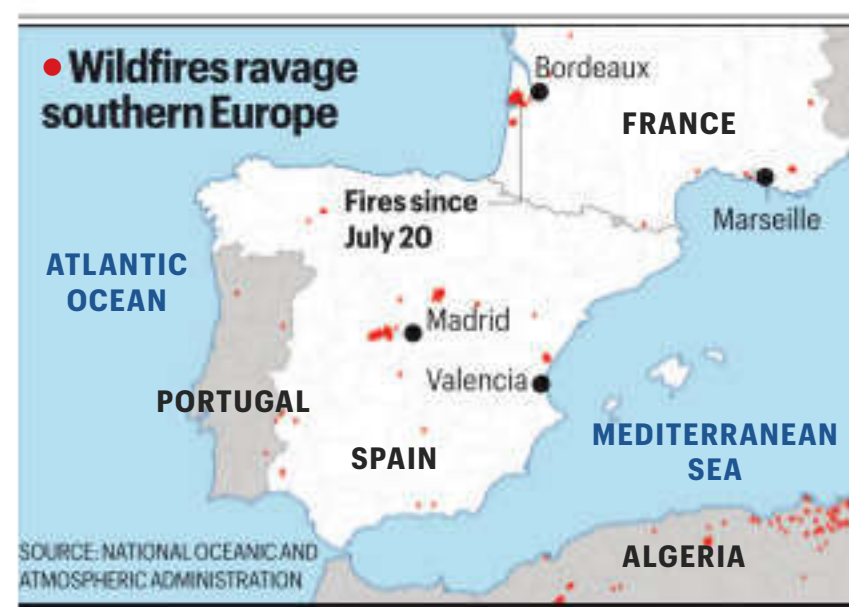
Lege-Cap Ferret, July 29

A WILDFIRE covering an area four times the size of Paris remained uncontained in south-west France on Wednesday as temperatures were forecast to reach 40 C, threatening to erase firefighters' overnight gains.

Authorities in the Gironde region said the blaze had not spread further during a calm night, but warned that forecast heat and winds could cause the flames to surge again.

At the command centre in Lege, firefighters bent over maps spread across a car hood as commanders tracked three danger zones: northern Cap-Ferret, the wooded corridor around Marcheprime, Cestas and Saint-Jean-d'Illac, and a military site near Martignas, where a significant new outbreak required a major deployment.

Over 2,200 firefighters and



Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1

over 20 aircraft remain mobilised, supported by crews from across France and European partners. "We strike quickly and strike hard at any new smoke emissions," Gironde fire commander Matthieu Jomain said.

Meteo-France, the national meteorological service, said Wednesday would be the hottest and driest day of the week, with elevated wildfire danger across every region of the country.

Spain is braced for its fourth heat wave of the summer, with several blazes still out of control, including the largest in its recorded history. Even so, Spanish authorities began lifting evacuation and stay-at-home orders.

Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F>

Top court refuses to ban Lord Jagannath film, defends artistic freedom

Ananthakrishnan G
New Delhi, July 29

THE SUPREME Court on Wednesday dismissed petitions seeking a ban on the release of the animated film *Mahaprabhu Jagannath*, observing that accepting the argument that it offends the religious sentiments of some people would leave no room for any creativity in the country.

A bench of Justices B V Nagarathna and R. Mahadevan refused to modify its earlier order allowing the release of the film and said it had already been granted a certificate by the Central Board of Film Certification (CBFC). The court had earlier allowed the release of the film on or after July 28, following the conclusion of the Rath Yatra.

The bench was hearing peti-

tions by a devotee and the temple committee against the go-ahead for the movie.

Pointing out extensive “research goes into” making such movies, Justice Nagarathna said, “Just because there are two or three sensitive people, we will pass an extreme order that with respect to deity, there shall be no creativity, no literature, no sculpture?... Animation films are for children. Artists can't be taken to ransom like this.”

The film was previously scheduled for release on July 17, but the Odisha High Court stayed the release on July 15. The high court order came on a Public Interest Litigation (PIL) seeking directions to restrain the filmmakers from public exhibition, screening, or releasing the film within the state.



An 850-seat Lok Sabha means more MPs, less Parliament

**THAROORTHINK**

BY SHASHI THAROOR

Law is in, lawmakers should speak for young

THE DEBATE on the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill 2026 — passed by voice vote amid sloganeering in the Lok Sabha Wednesday — carried echoes of the street agitation that had raged outside the House. The over a month-long protests by students, led by the Cockroach Janta Party in the wake of the NEET examination paper leak, compelled Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan to resign. They also prodded the government to tighten the existing law, making it more stringent in terms of punishments and fines, and setting up fast-track courts that will work to defined timelines. The change of minister, and the harder law, however, are just the beginning. The momentum built by the students' protests must not be lost — it must lead to larger and more meaningful changes in the education system, and re-energise structures of accountability and reform. And in that process, people's representatives on both sides of the aisle must step up to the challenge — because Parliament has a crucial role to play. It is MPs' responsibility now to ensure that the House opens its doors to let in the concerns and anxieties of the young that filled the streets till only a few days ago.

Some readings of the street protests by students have painted them as antagonistic to democratically elected people's representatives and constitutionally mandated institutions. It is true that the students' uprising rang with accumulated anger and resentment at the failure or inability of institutions — of government primarily, but also arguably of Opposition and Parliament — to address the crises that weigh down the education system or to assuage their apprehensions about dwindling opportunities for employment that is dignified and fulfilling. At the same time, however, the protests must be read as an appeal to those same institutions, to listen and respond, and to search for solutions. The movement on the street has made itself heard. Now Parliament must take on the hard and patient work of redesigning, correcting and finetuning educational structures and processes.

If Parliament is unable to step up to the task, if it is held back from doing so by long-playing and debilitating syndromes, like growing political polarisation and erosion of reciprocity, it would be missing an extraordinary opportunity. It has a chance to restore the trust of the young in the system. A rare possibility — of renewing and re-imagining the institution's pact with the people — is at hand. The highest forum of democratic deliberation must not fail to seize it.

A medical education more inclusive

THE NATIONAL Medical Commission's (NMC) revised guidelines for admitting persons with disabilities to undergraduate medical courses mark an overdue shift towards making medical education more inclusive. Issued on Monday, the new benchmark stipulates that a candidate's eligibility for the MBBS course will be based on a functional assessment rather than merely a certificate recording the disability. Designated medical boards will carry out evaluations. The message is significant: Disability, by itself, should not be treated as a disqualification. What matters is whether an aspiring doctor can acquire the competencies necessary to practise medicine, with appropriate support. The guidelines recognise that technology, institutional support and accessible infrastructure play an important role in determining whether disability becomes a barrier.

Framed around rigid thresholds and broad categories, the earlier guidelines often functioned less as tools of assessment than as instruments of exclusion. Applicants could be declared ineligible simply because they belonged to a particular disability category or crossed a prescribed threshold, regardless of whether they could complete the MBBS course. The guidelines were challenged several times, including before the Supreme Court, where petitioners argued that blanket exclusions violated the Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act, 2016. Last year, the Court observed that "systemic discrimination against persons with benchmark disabilities should be eliminated".

The real test of the revised guidelines will lie in their implementation. Functional assessments must not become another source of arbitrary decision-making. Without clear evaluation protocols, similarly placed candidates could receive different outcomes depending on the medical board before which they appear. The NMC should, therefore, develop standards that minimise subjectivity while preserving the flexibility that individual cases require. It should also revisit the SC's direction that every medical board include doctors with disabilities — a safeguard that will strengthen the credibility of the process. The Commission must view inclusivity not as a compliance exercise prompted by litigation but as an ongoing commitment. The new guidelines should be seen not as the final word but as the foundation of a medical education system that judges aspirant doctors on their abilities, and not by what could hold them back.

ceases to function as a deliberative body and deteriorates into a chaotic colosseum where only a select few can speak, while the rest are reduced to passive spectators, mere numbers on voting machines.

After all, the United States House of Representatives was legally capped at 435 in 1929, when the United States population stood at 120 million. Today, the American population has tripled to over 335 million, yet the size of the House remains at 435. Americans recognise that increasing the number of representatives to match population growth would paralyse the legislative process. Instead, each member simply represents a larger number of voters, relying on robust local staff, modern communication, and a highly organised committee system to bridge the governance gap. Indian MPs can do that too.

The realities of an 850-member Lok Sabha are devastating for individual legislators. In a standard parliamentary session, time is an unyielding, scarce resource. Consider the daily Question Hour or a standard legislative debate on a complex bill. If a debate is allocated four hours, and time is distributed according to party strength, at most 15-20 MPs out of 850 will be able to participate. In practice, backbenchers and members of smaller parties will be mostly silenced.

With an oversized Parliament, a vast majority of MPs will never get to ask a question, initiate a private member's bill, or participate in a substantive debate during their entire five-year tenure. They will be transformed into silent placeholders, raising their hands when the party commands. This will worsen an already distressing trend in Indian governance: The shrinking role (and systemic degradation) of Parliament. In recent years, the number of days Parliament meets

Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F>

An oversized legislature where the vast majority of members have no voice suits an executive that prefers compliance over scrutiny

annually has steadily declined, bills have been passed via voice vote within minutes without standing committee scrutiny, and the Opposition is frequently sidelined. Flooding the chamber with hundreds of additional members will accelerate this marginalisation, burying quality under the sheer weight of quantity.

An oversized legislature where the vast majority of members have no voice suits an executive that prefers compliance over scrutiny. When a Parliament becomes too large to debate, it naturally cedes its oversight power to the executive cabinet. The individual lawmaker loses leverage, and the House is reduced to a notice board and a rubber stamp.

This structural transformation bears an ominous resemblance to the authoritarian legislative model in Beijing or Pyongyang. Specifically, an 850-seat Lok Sabha risks becoming a deserversion of the Chinese People's Political Consultative Conference or the North Korean Supreme People's Assembly — enormous, unwieldy bodies designed to look grand, representative, and pluralistic, but reduced to applauding set speeches by the Great Leader. Their sheer size guarantees they cannot engage in real legislative negotiation or challenge the ruling executive. They exist to perform consensus, not to build it through debate. If India builds a massive legislature where MPs are stripped of their voices due to the arithmetic of time constraints, it will have successfully hollowed out its democracy, replacing a vibrant deliberative body with a performative pageant. Far better to save the extra expenditure on salaries, accommodation, travel and pensions for 300 more MPs and instead build a serious office building for the existing MPs near Parliament, as every other democracy provides its legislators.

The government's primary defence — that a single MP cannot effectively represent 2 to 3 million citizens — is a fallacy that misinterprets the role of a national lawmaker. An MP's constitutional duty is national legislation, foreign policy, macroeconomic governance, and holding the Union executive accountable. They are not municipal councillors or MLAs. If India established a sharp, institutional demarcation between the roles of Members of Legislative Assemblies (MLAs) and Members of Parliament (MPs), a smaller, focused group of MPs could easily represent large constituencies. Local grievances, municipal infrastructure, and civic amenities fall squarely within the domain of state legislatures and local panchayats or municipal corporations under the 73rd and 74th Amendments; as population increases, expand the number of MLAs! If local governance frameworks are empowered, the local citizen does not need to look to an MP for everyday civic needs. By keeping the Lok Sabha compact and focused on national governance, and leaving localised representation to state and municipal levels, India could maintain a highly efficient, effective, and truly participative federal structure, without ruining the functionality of Parliament.

The proposal to expand the Lok Sabha to 850 would create a House that is not a forum for governance but an echo chamber for the government. As we contemplate the future of our democracy, we must realise that true representation lies in the quality of debate, the rigour of legislative committee scrutiny, and the empowerment of local levels of government — not in creating an unwieldy mega-chamber that replaces democratic discourse with empty theatre.

The writer is a fourth-term Congress MP from Thiruvananthapuram

Dengue vaccine must complement prevention

**RAJIB DASGUPTA**

INDIA HAS taken an important step in the fight against dengue. On July 21, the Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation granted marketing authorisation to Qdenga, the country's first approved dengue vaccine. It has been approved in 42 countries. Over 24 million doses have been administered worldwide, and it has the WHO's imprimatur.

Dengue, one of the world's fastest-spreading mosquito-borne viral diseases, is caused by four closely related virus types — DENV-1, DENV-2, DENV-3 and DENV-4 — and is transmitted primarily by the *Aedes aegypti* mosquito. Clinical trials have shown that Qdenga provides long-lasting protection against all four dengue virus types in people who have had the disease. It has also been shown to protect against DENV-1 and DENV-2 among people who have never had dengue, with particularly strong protection against DENV-2, on which the vaccine is based.

The vaccine is administered in two doses. If the second is delayed, the schedule does not need to be restarted; the missed dose can be given at the earliest opportunity. It is not recommended for children under six because of lower efficacy and the relatively low prevalence of prior dengue infection in that age group. The WHO does not recommend its use beyond 60 years until there is more evidence on safety and efficacy. It should not be administered to pregnant women, women planning pregnancy within one month of vaccination, breastfeeding mothers, immunocompromised individuals, or those receiving immunosuppressive therapies such as chemotherapy or high-dose corticosteroids.

Affordability is likely to determine uptake. At an expected price of Rs 3,000-6,000 per dose, initial demand is likely to come primarily from the urban middle class. Whether the vaccine should eventually be included in the Universal Immunisation Programme is a complex question. The WHO recommends that countries consider introducing Qdenga into routine immunisation only in areas where dengue transmission is a significant public health threat. Indicators include a dengue seroprevalence exceeding 60 per cent by the age of nine or a mean age of dengue-related hospitalisation below 16 years. India will need robust epidemiological data to determine which regions meet these criteria before considering wider public funding.

Vaccination, however, is only one part of the solution. The same *Aedes* mosquitoes also transmit chikungunya and Zika, making integrated vector management indispensable. Eliminating mosquito breeding sites through better drainage and waste disposal must remain the first line of defence. These efforts should be complemented by biological measures such as larvivorous fish, judicious use of chemical and microbial control methods, stronger coordination across agencies, and sustained community participation. Improving public awareness and health literacy is equally important. Qdenga is a significant addition to India's public health arsenal, but it should complement, not replace, a comprehensive strategy for controlling mosquito-borne diseases.

Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1
The writer is chairperson, Centre of Social Medicine and Community Health, JNU

Clinical trials have shown that Qdenga provides long-lasting protection against all four dengue virus types in people who have had the disease. It has also been shown to protect against DENV-1 and DENV-2 among people who have never had dengue

India's fertility decline story is not yet a crisis. It is a policy story



SRINIVAS GOLI AND K S JAMES

TODAY, INDIA'S most popular headline about its population is simple: The average woman is having about two children over her lifetime. That single figure has become a shorthand for "India has reached replacement-level fertility", and in one sense it is true. But successive Sample Registration System and National Family Health Survey rounds tell us something that should make us pause: India has achieved below-replacement fertility despite the near universality of marriage — only about 1 per cent of women remain never married by ages 45-49, the median age at first birth is 21.2 years, and childbearing is virtually imposed within marriage with a lower socio-economic status, a demographic pathway that sharply contrasts with the experience of most other low-fertility countries. Therefore, this is not the classic story of low birth rates driven by late marriage or people choosing not to marry. So what, exactly, is inside that two-children average and does it tell us the whole truth?

The widely used total fertility rate (TFR — average number of births per woman) counts all births, including births women did not plan or want, as well as those that happen because families keep trying until they get a son. Thus, it hides actual fertility intentions. Demographers have a name for the part of fertility that represents births women actually wanted: The "wanted fertility rate". If you count only the births that match what women say they intended, their preferred family size can be obtained. The gap between wanted and actual fertility has narrowed over the years but remains significant. Nationally, women have an average of 2.0 children, while their desired family size is about 1.6, leaving a gap of 0.4. Around eight states (Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Jharkhand, Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh, Assam, Haryana) have a gap of more than 0.3 children per woman.

Here is where India gets genuinely unusual. The country has managed to bring birth rates down to near-replacement levels, and yet millions of women still can't reliably prevent pregnancies they don't want. How can both be true?

The answer lies in how Indian women control their fertility:



ILLUSTRATION: TANUSHRI MITRA

Women have children, reach their desired family size, and then stop permanently using sterilisation. What's largely missing are the tools that help young couples space their children to delay a first birth, or wait a few years between children. When family planning arrives late, unintended pregnancies tend to cluster in the early years of marriage, among the youngest women. This also reflects in relatively poor maternal and child health. Informed choice around sterilisation also remains partial. When women whose sterilisation was not a fully informed choice are counted alongside women with unmet need, India's "unwanted family planning" problem looks considerably larger than the headline numbers suggest.

There is another force propping up India's birth numbers: Son preference. In several states, many families don't stop having children after one or two, they stop after they've had a son. Analyses of NFHS microdata from the 1990s found that a disproportionate share of "unwanted" births — beyond what women said they wanted — were daughters. As son preference weakens — and slowly, it is weakening, particularly among younger and more educated families — this hidden fertility inflation will deflate.

India's fertility decline story is not yet a crisis. It is a policy story, one about helping women and couples align their actual lives with their intended ones. Unintended pregnancies have already fallen reasonably from 21 per cent in 2005-06 to 8 per cent in 2019-21. If unmet need for family planning continues to fall, if spacing methods reach young couples who need them most, and if son preference keeps fading, India's birth rate will fall further on its own. Not because families are being pressured, but because many of the births that currently hold the number up were never truly planned in the first place.

The baby India didn't plan for may become rarer in future. The more pressing concern now is the recent decline in the use of modern contraceptive methods, which risks leaving the country's remaining unwanted-fertility gap in place even as the headline TFR falls. This becomes more critical when only 30 per cent of women seek a second birth on their own. India needs to monitor fertility preferences, both intended and unintended births, and ensure couples are able to realise their own choices instead of overall birth rates.

Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1
Goli is associate professor at the International Institute for Population Sciences and the author of A Treatise on Families in Contemporary India and James is a demographer and professional specialist at Princeton University. Views are personal



KAMINI WALIA

THE LATEST global study in *The Lancet Public Health* has again highlighted what infectious disease experts in India have known for years: India uses too many broad-spectrum "watch" antibiotics and too few first-line "access" antibiotics. It estimates that India's antibiotic consumption is higher than the optimal target and that the antibiotic mix is skewed towards drugs that should ideally be reserved for more serious infections.

The tendency to overuse broad-spectrum antibiotics has been documented repeatedly over the past two decades through surveillance studies, hospital audits and national antimicrobial resistance (AMR) programmes. The more important question is why physicians continue to prescribe them.

The answer lies less in irrationality than in the realities of clinical practice. Doctors frequently prescribe antibiotics before a definitive diagnosis is available because patients often present late. Diagnostic facilities are limited or unreliable, and treatment decisions cannot always wait. Similarly, inadequate infection prevention and control in healthcare facilities increases the likelihood of healthcare-associated infections, prompting clinicians to choose broader-spectrum agents from the outset. In other words, antibiotics are often used to compensate for systemic weaknesses.

Clinicians need training in antimicrobial stewardship and evidence-based prescribing. Communities must understand that antibiotics do not treat viral infections

On antibiotics, problem isn't just overprescribing

If India wants to reduce inappropriate antibiotic use, it must address these underlying drivers. The first priority is strengthening infection prevention. Better water, sanitation and hygiene, wider use of vaccines, and sustained investment in infection prevention and control programmes in hospitals will reduce the burden of infections that require antibiotics. While initiatives like Kayakalp have improved cleanliness in public hospitals, preventing healthcare-associated infections requires continuous investment in trained infection-control personnel, surveillance systems, antimicrobial stewardship and institutional accountability.

The second priority is strengthening diagnostic capacity. Rational antibiotic prescribing is only possible when clinicians have confidence in laboratory results. India has begun building this through the National Health Mission, Free Diagnostics Service Initiative, National Essential Diagnostics List and expanded lab networks. Improving laboratory quality, accreditation, turnaround time and confidence in microbiology reports is equally important.

Education is central. Clinicians need training in antimicrobial stewardship and evidence-based prescribing. Communities must understand that antibiotics do not treat viral infections and that demanding them for every fever is harmful in the long term.

It is equally important to recognise that India has not been standing still. Over the past decade, the country has established a National Action Plan on AMR, expanded surveillance through the National Centre for Disease Control and Indian Council of Medical Research, introduced antimicrobial stewardship initiatives, strengthened essential diagnostics, regulated fixed-dose combinations and increased political recognition of AMR as a national priority. These are substantial structural reforms that take years to translate into measurable changes.

A country that accounts for nearly one-fifth of the world's population and manages one of the largest public health systems cannot transform antibiotic use overnight. Progress should be judged not only by current consumption patterns but also by the strength and direction of ongoing reforms.

International reports are valuable when they stimulate action, but repeating what is already well established adds little unless accompanied by practical solutions. Reducing antimicrobial resistance will not be achieved by asking doctors simply to prescribe fewer antibiotics. This can cost lives. It will be achieved by creating a health system where they can safely prescribe the right antibiotic, for the right patient, at the right time and the country is committed to achieving this.

The writer is senior scientist and programme officer, AMR, ICMR

Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Vn2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F>

• ECONOMY

As conflict expands to Red Sea, India’s crude options



SUKALP SHARMA

THE THEATRE of the West Asia conflict, earlier limited to the Strait of Hormuz from the perspective of India’s crude oil imports, has now widened. Last week, the Yemen-based Houthi militia announced it would target Saudi Arabian tankers attempting to cross the Bab el-Mandeb Strait and indeed attacked a few ships.

Like the Strait of Hormuz, the Bab el-Mandeb — which connects the Red Sea to the Gulf of Aden and the Arabian Sea — is another critical chokepoint for global trade, and energy supplies in particular.

Saudi Arabia was using the route to export its oil, including to India, as Strait of Hormuz traffic fell to a trickle. The Houthi impact is already visible, with vessel crossings via Bab el-Mandeb slumping to an average of 31 per day over the past three days from 43 per day in the first half of July, according to S&P Global data from July 27.

The Houthi blockade could delay oil shipments to Asia by forcing tankers to sail through the Suez Canal and then taking the circuitous route around Africa. This would add up to four weeks to the journey, and keep oil prices elevated. This matters for India, which depends on imports to meet over 88% of its oil requirement. But according to analysts, the current risks appear manageable despite the concerns.

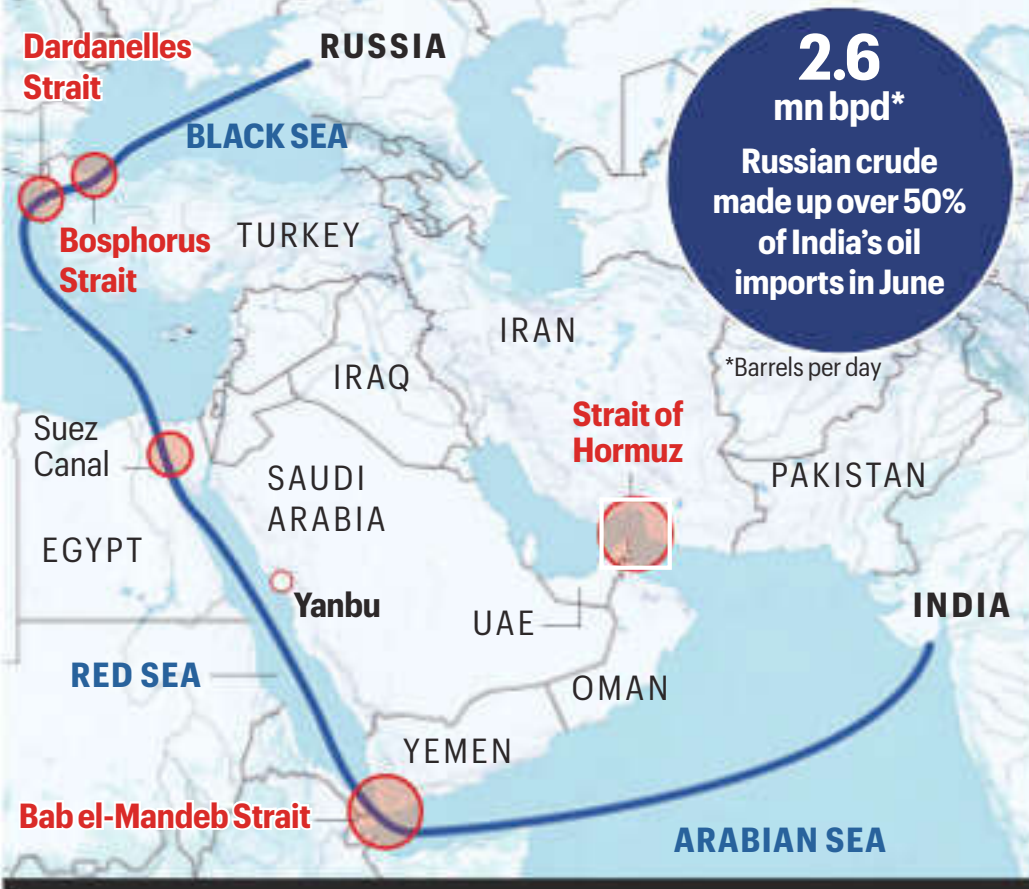
The first and the most obvious fall-back for the country is Russian crude, the mainstay of its oil imports. So far, Russian oil appears to be safe from Houthi attacks, as it was in earlier Bab el-Mandeb blockades by the Iran-backed militia.

Russian oil exports are also under pressure amid Ukraine’s strikes against energy export infrastructure. But the expectation is that while this may restrict the availability of Moscow’s crude, and thus drive up prices, any material impact on India would be limited from a supply security perspective.

The Russian option

“As per the predictions, if Russian oil (coming through the Red Sea route) is not affected and the blockade is targeted only

• RUSSIAN OIL FLOWS TO INDIA VIA RED SEA UNAFFECTED SO FAR



Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F> alternative sources. Indian refiners are likely to increase purchases of Russian spot barrels where available, while also drawing on commercial crude inventories to bridge any temporary supply gaps,” said Sumit Ritolia, manager, refining and modelling at commodity market analytics firm Kpler.

Amid the Strait of Hormuz crisis, India’s Russian crude imports have increased from around 1 million bpd in February to record highs of about 2.6 million bpd in June, accounting for over 50% of India’s overall oil imports. July oil imports from Russia are also tracking at similar levels, as per ship-tracking data. Before the war, over 40% of India’s oil imports came from West Asia via the Strait of Hormuz.

“As more refineries return, fewer barrels will be available for export. Given Russia’s recent fuel shortages, Moscow is likely to reduce the record 4.5 million bpd of crude exported in June, of which about 55% went to India. If all major refineries resume normal operations, Russian crude exports could fall by as much as 1 million bpd,” said Katona.

Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mJm2gl

Dual chokepoints

● With traffic through the Strait of Hormuz down to a trickle, Saudi Arabia was using the Bab el-Mandeb to export its oil, including to India.

● Now, the Houthi blockade on Saudi-linked shipping and energy supplies would force tankers to sail westward instead, through the Suez Canal, and then taking the circuitous route around Africa.

● The Suez Canal-Red Sea route is also the primary route for Russian oil to reach Indian ports.

● So far, Russian oil appears to be safe from Houthi attacks as it was in earlier Bab el-Mandeb blockades by the Iran-backed militia.

● But Russian exports are also under pressure amid Ukraine’s strikes.

Emergency options, beyond Russia

West Asian crude that can bypass regional chokepoints are practical emergency options for Indian refiners.

● There are also options to increase purchases of American and South American oil, but the long voyage times are a challenge.

India faces fresh oil supply risks as the Houthis threaten Saudi shipments via Red Sea. Russian crude and alternative sources could cushion the impact

will try to absorb as much Urals (Russia’s flagship crude grade) as possible, its incremental availability is limited as China and Turkey are competing for the same barrels,” Abu Dhabi-based energy analyst Natalia Katona told *The Indian Express*.

The risks to Russia’s oil exports

According to industry experts and analysts, a key uncertainty from India’s point of view is whether Russia can sustain higher export availability, given the impact of continued Ukrainian attacks on parts of its upstream and downstream oil infrastructure.

“While the Strait of Hormuz and Red Sea remain strategically important, the uninterrupted operation of Russian export infrastructure — particularly Black Sea terminals such as Novorossiysk — has become equally, if not more, critical for India’s crude supply...any disruption to Saudi exports via the Red Sea would have a relatively smaller impact on India’s overall crude availability than a sustained disruption to Russian Black Sea exports,” said Ritolia.

Unlike the Red Sea, where some cargoes can be rerouted around Africa, export alternatives for oil exported from Black Sea ports are limited. Any prolonged disruption there could tighten global crude availability, disrupt trade flows, and directly affect India’s largest source of imported crude.

According to Katona, the larger immediate concern is Novorossiysk’s Sheskaris terminal, which halted operations last week following Ukrainian attacks on regional oil infrastructure. The terminal is particularly important for India, as of the 1.1 million bpd crude loaded there in June, around 840,000 bpd went to India. Overall, the Novorossiysk complex supplied about 28% of India’s Russian crude imports in June.

Russia had recently increased crude exports as Ukrainian attacks sent several refineries offline for repairs, which freed additional barrels for the export market — mainly China and India. In the medium term, the return of the affected Russian refining capacity is also a risk for India, particularly if the Hormuz crisis doesn’t abate.

“As more refineries return, fewer barrels will be available for export. Given Russia’s recent fuel shortages, Moscow is likely to reduce the record 4.5 million bpd of crude exported in June, of which about 55% went to India. If all major refineries resume normal operations, Russian crude exports could fall by as much as 1 million bpd,” said Katona.

• LEGAL

As late PM Singh gets clean chit, recalling the coal block ‘scam’ case

Nirbhay Thakur
New Delhi, July 29

THE SUPREME Court Wednesday gave a posthumous clean chit to the late former Prime Minister Manmohan Singh in a case pertaining to the alleged coal block “scam” that the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) was probing.

A bench of Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, Justice Joymalya Bagchi and Justice V Mohana accepted the CBI’s decision to close the case against Singh, who passed away on December 26, 2024, and allowed his appeal challenging the 2015 trial court summons to him in the case.

In August and October 2014, the CBI had filed closure reports before the trial court of then Special Judge Bharat Parashar, finding no case against Singh. The special court, however, rejected the reports, took cognisance of the case, and summoned Singh in March 2015. The Supreme Court had stayed the summons to Singh in April 2015.

The case

The case pertains to alleged irregularities in the allocation of Odisha’s Talabira-2 coal block in 2005, when Manmohan Singh was PM and held the charge of the Coal Ministry portfolio. The block was allocated to Mahanadi Coalfields Ltd, Neyveli Lignite Corporation Ltd (NLC) and Hindalco after the three entities formed a joint venture.

The alleged irregularities pertained to the inclusion of Hindalco (an Aditya Birla Group flagship company) in the allotment of the block alongside the two public sector undertakings. While the 25th Screening Committee had originally recommended allocating the block to NLC, the decision was revisited after Birla wrote to the Prime Minister’s Office (PMO) requesting coal allocation.

COAL CASE

● A CAG report showed inefficient and possibly illegal allocation of coal blocks between 2004 and 2009.

● It estimated a loss to the exchequer to the tune of Rs 10.7 lakh crore, but later toned this down to Rs 1.86 lakh crore.

scious effort” to “somehow accommodate” Hindalco in the process by approving Parakh’s proposal to accommodate the company in the block, while ignoring notes of caution from two PMO officials regarding relaxation of previously approved guidelines.

The judge noted that the allocation “nullified” the Screening Committee’s recommendations, and that it hurt the NLC and its efforts to establish a 2,000 megawatt power plant in Odisha.

What Singh’s lawyers said

Now, more than a decade after the special court’s summons, the top court was hearing a batch of petitions in connection with the coal block allotment cases when Senior Advocate Kapil Sibal, appearing for Singh, referred to the case against the late PM.

Sibal said though the matter had become infructuous after Singh’s death, the special court’s remarks against him ought to be expunged. Senior Advocate A M Singhvi, also representing Singh, urged the Supreme Court to do away with the remarks.

• SECURITY

Besra arrest may not stop Maoist insurgency, but effectively ends the movement

Deeptiman Tiwary
New Delhi, July 29

THE ARREST of senior Communist Party of India (Maoist) Politburo member Misir Besra in Jharkhand marks the culmination of one of India’s longest counter-insurgency campaigns. For nearly four decades, Besra remained one of the organisation’s most influential leaders in the Jharkhand-Bihar region, surviving repeated security offensives even as the rest of the Maoist leadership was steadily eliminated through encounters, arrests and surrenders. With his arrest, the CPI (Maoist) has effectively lost the last active member of the leadership that built the organisation into a nationwide insurgent force.

Who is Misir Besra?

Born into a Santhal Adivasi family in Madnadih village of Jharkhand’s Giridih district, Misir Besra studied in Dhanbad before completing graduation and postgraduation in political science at Rajganj. It was during the sociopolitical churn of the

Jharkhand movement in the late 1980s that he was drawn to Maoist ideology. Leaving behind his young wife and family, he joined the Maoist Communist Centre, which later merged with the People’s War Group in 2004 to form the CPI (Maoist).

Besra’s rise was driven by military success. Soon after Jharkhand was carved out of Bihar in 2000, he was linked to a series of attacks on security forces, including the 2003 and 2004 IED ambushes in West Singhbhum’s Bitkilsoy and Baliba that killed 55 personnel. The attacks earned him a place in the Central Military Commission and charge of the Eastern Regional Bureau, making him one of the organisation’s most influential leaders in eastern India.

For years, agencies knew little about the man behind these attacks until his arrest during a routine vehicle check in 2007. Two years later, he escaped in one of the country’s most audacious Maoist jailbreaks when around 30 cadres attacked a court complex in Bihar’s Lakhisarai, killing a policeman.

Besra remained underground for the

next 17 years despite carrying a Rs 1 crore bounty and facing over 150 criminal cases.

What does his arrest mean for the Maoist movement?

Besra’s arrest completes the dismantling of the CPI (Maoist)’s central leadership that security agencies have pursued over the past two years. Unlike earlier phases of the anti-Maoist campaign, which largely targeted field commanders, the recent offensive focused on decapitating the organisation’s command structure.

At the start of 2024, the Politburo and Central Committee together had 21 leaders directing operations, recruitment and strategy across the country. Over the next two years, 12 were killed, seven surrendered and one was arrested. Besra, the only leader left underground, has now been captured.

In the Dandakaranya region (spanning Chhattisgarh, Odisha, Telangana, and Andhra Pradesh) — the Maoists’ principal military theatre — the State Committee was dismantled through killings, arrests and sur-

renders. The Madhya Pradesh-Maharashtra-Chhattisgarh committee disappeared after its remaining three members surrendered, while Odisha and Telangana also lost their state leaderships. The Disturbed Region Bureau, which coordinated operations across states, was similarly broken up.

Almost every nationally recognised Maoist leader has now either been killed or surrendered. General secretary Nambala Keshava Rao alias Basavaraju and Battalion 1 commander Madvi Hidma were killed, while senior leaders including Mallojula Venugopal Rao (Sonu) and Thippiri Tirupathi (Devuji) surrendered.

With Besra’s arrest, the CPI (Maoist) is left with scattered armed groups led by lower-level commanders, but no nationally recognised leadership capable of directing a coordinated insurgency across states.

What action has the government taken over the past two years?

Security forces pushed deeper into strongholds such as Bastar and Abujhmad,

established forward operating bases, improved road connectivity, and increasingly relied on intelligence-led operations instead of large-area combing exercises. Local forces, particularly Chhattisgarh’s District Reserve Guards, also eroded the Maoists’ long-held advantage in jungle warfare.

Alongside military operations, the Centre expanded rehabilitation packages for surrendering cadres. The combined approach has sharply reduced the Maoists’ geographical footprint. According to government data, Left Wing Extremism-related violence has fallen by more than 80% since 2010, and by early 2026 only seven districts remained categorised as LWE-affected, three of them severely so.

Can the movement survive?

The arrest of Besra does not automatically end Maoist violence. Small groups remain active, particularly in parts of Bastar, and could continue sporadic attacks or extortion. But security officials believe the CPI (Maoist) no longer possesses the leadership,

territorial control or depth needed to regenerate itself as a nationwide insurgency. Roads, connectivity and a stronger administrative presence have reduced the isolation that once enabled the movement to flourish.

Former Maoist leaders and security experts argue that the organisation also failed to adapt to changing conditions. Surveillance improved, security forces established a permanent presence in former strongholds and tribal aspirations shifted towards education, welfare and employment. But the CPI (Maoist) remained committed to a strategy of protracted armed struggle.

What challenges does govt face?

Security experts caution that eliminating the leadership is only one part of the challenge. The areas once dominated by Maoists continue to face problems of governance, infrastructure and access to public services. They argue that security gains must now be consolidated by strengthening civil administration — through schools, health centres, roads, communications and jobs.

Harjinder ‘lands’ second successive weightlifting medal

Nitin Sharma
Chandigarh, July 29

SOME MORE farmland.

That was the thought that came to Harjinder Kaur's mind immediately after she won the Commonwealth Games silver medal in the women's 69kg weightlifting event.

The medal was an improvement on the one the girl from Punjab had clinched in the 71kg category at the previous edition in Birmingham. Since then, her marginal farming family had moved to a new house and bought some farmland in their village, and Harjinder's father Sahib Singh may interpret her latest achievement in terms of what it could provide the family materially. "We had marginal farmland and the income was

augmented by selling milk from the six buffaloes we owned. The bronze medal won in Birmingham landed me a job as an income tax inspector, apart from cash awards. I wanted to upgrade my medal here and now I will get some more farmland for my father," Harjinder told *The Indian Express*.

Harjinder lifted a total of 227 kg - 101kg in snatch and 126kg in clean and jerk - to finish behind Canadian Charlotte Simoneau (240kg —108kg and 132kg).

With the family owning six buffaloes, Harjinder got milk and home-made paneer. She would often help her father operate the chaff-cutting machine, and the strong physique came handy when Harjinder started playing kabaddi at Government Girls School at



Harjinder Kaur. PTI

Nabha, where she would commute daily by bicycle. She was then selected to play for Punjabi University, Patiala where 1990 Commonwealth Games weightlifting champion Paramjit Sharma took her under his wings. "She was healthy and I knew I could groom her into a good weight-

Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1
lifter. I put her initially in tug of war teams before starting weightlifting. Her mother sold her jewellery and the family took loans to support her training, which made Harjinder determined to excel in her sport," he told *The Indian Express*.

It was in 2019 that brother Pritpal Singh got a contractual job in the PWD department and with Harjinder too getting a scholarship from Punjabi University, the family's financial situation improved and she could focus solely on weightlifting.

Battling injuries

Last year, Harjinder suffered a wrist injury while a back problem that she suffered in 2019 also aggravated. She moved to the 69kg class and won the

bronze at the Commonwealth Championship in Ahmedabad with a mark of 222kg. Despite winning her second successive CWG medal on Tuesday, Harjinder knows she has work to do in the coming years.

"I have had some issues in my clean and jerk technique, and have been working on them for a few years. (National coach) Vijay Sharma sir has been working on getting some technical flaws rectified and the aim is to improve further," she said.

Meanwhile, mother Kuldeep knows what Harjinder would demand when she gets home from Glasgow. "She always asks me to cook vegetables like pumpkin, which she doesn't get to eat at hostels or abroad."